

The following excerpt is from my book, *My Life: Between Time & Eternity*.

My Greatest Failing: A Confession

By Terry Presgrove

My greatest failing in my seventy-six years has been my reluctance to love my fellow man as Christ instructed. When Christ commands us to love others, He is not merely speaking of those in our immediate circle—our family, friends, or those who are easy to get along with. His call is far more radical. Jesus said plainly, “But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you” (Matthew 5:44, ESV).

He isn’t speaking only of those who share our faith, values, or political convictions. He commands us to love the unlovely—the rude, the irritating, even those whose beliefs strike at the very heart of what we hold most sacred. This has long been my Achilles’ heel. As an old Marine combat veteran, I especially struggle with those I find abrasive or those who embrace ideologies that run counter to everything I have fought for and believed.

Luke 6:27–30 presents a grounded, practical, and deeply challenging interpretation of Jesus’ teaching. It recognizes that these verses aren’t just lofty ideals, but a radical call to action.

A. Love Your Enemies

Luke 6:27

Jesus defines love here not as an emotion, but as action. Biblical love—agape—is a choice, not a feeling. Waiting until we “feel love” for enemies before acting in love is not only impractical, it’s unbiblical. What Jesus commands is willful, sacrificial behavior that mirrors God’s own grace toward sinners.

“While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

That’s the model: acting in love before it is deserved, and regardless of the emotional pull.

As much as many of us would like to find loopholes—there are none. The passage offers no exceptions or fine print.

This truth pierces me. I have often withheld love under the pretense of principle, when in reality it was pride. My refusal to act in love toward those I deeply disagreed with was not holiness—it was hardness of heart.

B. Bless Those Who Curse You

Luke 6:28

This command reaches straight to the tongue. It’s not merely about withholding retaliation — it’s about deliberately choosing words that build up, even when others use theirs to tear down.

It's easy for me to strike back, and for others, to stay silent or simply walk away. But Jesus calls us beyond that. To bless those who curse us is an intentional act of verbal grace—a supernatural response that confounds the world and reflects the heart of heaven.

Far too often, I've chosen silence, sarcasm, or even retaliation over blessing. I've failed to speak life when confronted with insult or injury. But I see now—that wasn't neutrality or wisdom—it was selfish pride.

C. Turn the Other Cheek

Luke 6:29

Understanding the cultural context is vital. In Jesus' time, a slap on the cheek was a public insult meant to humiliate. Turning the other cheek was not submission—it was a form of dignified resistance. It exposed the aggressor without replicating their hostility.

Jesus isn't calling for passivity. He's forbidding retaliation. He's commanding us to overcome evil with good (Romans 12:21).

As someone trained in defense, retaliation feels natural—even demanded. But Christ shows us a better way: not weakness, but strength under control. Courage wrapped in humility.

D. Do Not Ask for Goods Back

Luke 6:30

This may be the hardest command of all. It assaults our sense of fairness and justice. Sacrificial giving only makes sense if we trust God to provide.

Without that trust, this command seems impossible. But with faith in a generous Father, it becomes the gateway to freedom.

The real question isn't, "Will I be taken advantage of?" It's, "Am I willing to lose something for the sake of someone else's redemption?"

Here Jesus reminds us that Christians must never value possessions above people. To cling to our cloak, our money, or our reputation at the expense of another's soul is to miss the heart of the gospel. Earthly goods are temporary; our fellow men and women are eternal. When we hold possessions more tightly than relationships, we reveal that our trust rests in things rather than in God.

The boundary of such sacrifice is love—not convenience, not comfort, and certainly not ego.

I have rarely lived at that limit. I've drawn lines of protection around my time, my reputation, and my possessions—lines more reflective of selfishness and fear than faith.

And yet, while Christ calls us to hold possessions loosely, He also calls us to hold life sacred—including the lives of those entrusted to our care. This balance between surrender and protection leads us naturally to the question of self-defense.

E. Love and Self-Defense Are Not Contradictions

When Jesus told His disciples, “But now if you have a purse, take it, and also a bag; and if you don’t have a sword, sell your cloak and buy one” (Luke 22:36), He was preparing them for a dangerous world where His physical presence would no longer protect them. The sword was not a license for aggression, but recognition of a legitimate right to self-defense.

Scripture supports this principle. “If a thief is caught breaking in at night and is struck a fatal blow, the defender is not guilty of bloodshed” (Exodus 22:2, NIV). Likewise, Paul reminds us that to care for one’s household is a Christian duty (1 Timothy 5:8)—and that care includes protection.

Self-defense, then, is not about vengeance, but stewardship. To protect one’s family from harm is an act of love, not hatred. To refuse to defend them would not reflect holiness, but neglect. And yet, even here, the cross sets the boundaries. When Peter struck the servant of the high priest in Gethsemane, Jesus said, “Put your sword back in its place... for all who draw the sword will die by the sword” (Matthew 26:52). The sword may preserve life, but it must never be wielded in pride, revenge, or hatred.

Christian love and self-defense are not enemies. Love may at times demand sacrifice; at other times it demands protection. In both, the Spirit calls us to act not from fear, but from faith, guarding life while refusing to surrender to bitterness.

F. The Heart of the Matter

These passages are not about becoming a doormat—they are about becoming a conduit of grace. They are about trusting God so completely that we no longer feel the need to guard our pride, our possessions, or even our rights, because we believe He will ultimately uphold and restore all things (1Peter 2:23).

Such love is nothing short of revolutionary—and humanly impossible. And that is precisely the point: it forces us to depend wholly on the Holy Spirit. Jesus does not call us to feel sentimental affection toward our enemies; He calls us to act in love—deliberately choosing to do good to those who may despise us. This love is not anchored in fluctuating emotion, but in the will: a conscious decision to extend grace, regardless of how we feel.

Yet loving others does not mean endorsing what is false. We are called to kindness, patience, and compassion—but never at the expense of God’s truth. True love is anchored in truth. It seeks the highest good for others, which means pointing them toward God, not affirming what draws them away from Him (Ephesians 4:15). Sometimes that requires “tough love”—speaking

the truth even when it wounds, always with the aim of restoration.

Real love never compromises truth—without truth, love dissolves into sentimentality; without love, truth becomes a weapon rather than a remedy. Love confronts sin not to condemn, but to restore—and that is exactly what Christ did for me (Romans 5:8).

G. The Cross Leaves No Excuse

The cross makes this personal. It removes every excuse I might cling to for withholding love. Jesus loved me at my most unlovable—when I was dead in sin, hostile to His truth, and utterly undeserving of grace. He sought me, not because of who I was, but because of who He is.

If I have been loved so completely, how can I withhold love from anyone else? Loving the unlovely may be the greatest challenge of the Christian life, but for the believer, it is not optional. Scripture declares, “We love because He first loved us” (1 John 4:19). If I claim to love God but harbor hatred toward my brother, I am deceiving myself.

By my own effort, I will fail. But God never commands what He will not also empower. When I yield to Him, the Spirit produces what I cannot: “love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control” (Galatians 5:22–23). The answer is not to grit my teeth and try harder—it is to surrender more fully. “God’s love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit” (Romans 5:5).

When we walk by the Spirit, we can love those we once found impossible to love—not because of who they are, but because of who Christ is in us. “It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (Galatians 2:20). And so, my prayer is simple: that God would break my heart for what breaks His—and soften my spirit toward those I find hardest to love.